

ROADSIDE DHABAS

Kishangarh | RAJASTHAN



Taking the high road

Greasy spoons and battered tables are becoming a thing of the past as gleaming interiors and pre-plated meals await hardy highway truck drivers

■ By Rohit Parihar

Sita Ram Singh, 29 and Nemi Chand Rawat, 31, have been driving trawlers from Delhi to Mumbai for the past seven years. Neighbours and cousins from a village near Pushkar in Rajasthan, they drive for three weeks in a month and get to be at home for only five days. "When I started, there were mostly small dhabas on the road and we preferred to cook our own meals," recalls Rawat. Their current stop is Kishangarh, a major marble market 25 km short of Ajmer, still a long haul from Mumbai port, their eventual destination, but they are feel-

Rajasthan has 11 such, of the 111 opened across the nation. "Since we are in the fuel business, our primary concern was to improve the quality of life of long distance drivers," says Reliance's Harkirat Uberoi. It's already made the company the nation's largest organised highway hospitality restaurant chain based on the franchisee mode.

From reasonably priced meals at Rs 35 for a simple thali and sanitised seats, the plazas are a cultural shift for those who take the road to Rajasthan. Rooms with charpoy for the night and clean washrooms with shared bathing facilities at Rs 5 complete the transformation. For Singh and Rawat, it's a refreshing

change from the old, often unhygienic washrooms and battered tables.

Pucca, tiled parking places have taken the place of muddy tracks where trucks always used to be in imminent danger of getting stuck. "We also desire to live better now," says Singh. Many truck drivers are now educated and good service gives them a sense of well-being. As Singh says, with a touch of wistfulness, he likes to be served by uniformed waiters who treat him with the same respect as other clients. "It is lot more fun to relax and eat while watching television instead of sitting by yourself," he says. A-1 Plazas are becoming popular with budget

tourists and students too. With a pilot project to open dormitories at three points on the east-west corridor, even an overnight stay at a dhaba, out in the open with the elements for company, might soon be history.

Life on the highway can be hard, and driving non-stop through the night a nightmare, but there's always time for a big bite into the big time.

HIGHWAY HIGHS:
Singh and Rawat at the Reliance plaza



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ing less homesick than usual. Unlike Punjab, where the dhaba culture has been linked to good food, in Rajasthan dhabas were mostly rather pokey places off the road, offering little variety.

But things are changing now. Gone are the days of greasy spoons and in their place are the swathe of Reliance's A-1 Plazas located at the company petrol pump stations.